

MY ANXIETY PROFILE

GOALS OF THE EXERCISE

1. Maintain a program of recovery free of addiction and excessive anxiety.
2. Understand the relationship between anxiety and addictive behaviors.
3. Increase insight and awareness related to feelings and processes associated with anxiety.
4. Decrease anxious thoughts and increase positive, self-enhancing self-talk.
5. Reduce overall stress levels, reducing excessive worry and muscle tension.
6. Strengthen belief in the capacity to self-manage anxiety without returning to addictive behaviors.

ADDITIONAL HOMEWORK THAT CAN BE APPLICABLE TO CLIENTS WHO EXPERIENCE ANXIETY ISSUES

- Coping with Addiction and PTSD or Other Anxiety Disorders
- Coping with Stress
- Correcting Distorted Thinking
- Handling Crisis
- Identifying Relapse Triggers and Cues
- Learning to Self-Soothe
- Safe and Peaceful Place Meditation
- Using Books and Other Media Resources

ADDITIONAL PROBLEMS FOR WHICH THIS EXERCISE MAY BE USEFUL

- Posttraumatic Stress Disorder (PTSD)
- Social Anxiety/Skills Deficit

SUGGESTIONS FOR PROCESSING THIS EXERCISE WITH THE CLIENT

The “My Anxiety Profile” activity is designed for clients who experience anxiety but feel helpless to change it or alter it. This exercise asks the client to first identify how he/she experiences anxiety physically, behaviorally, cognitively, and emotionally. Second, it asks him/her to develop a hierarchy of least to most anxiety-producing experiences. Finally, it asks the client to develop a plan for how

he/she will cope with feelings of anxiety. It is useful for some clients to externalize problems by giving them personalities and/or naming them, and then learning to view themselves as active opponents to those problems. This can allow the client to feel empowered and, perhaps for the first time, feel that he/she is not the problem but rather the solution. Follow-up can consist of teaching basic relaxation and imagery techniques to deal with all levels of anxiety. The client and the therapist can become a team in addressing the issue of anxiety.

MY ANXIETY PROFILE

Everyone experiences anxiety. It is often associated with fears and phobias, nervousness, and panic attacks. Some people are very aware of their anxiety, and others don't become aware of it until it is overwhelming. Some people experience anxiety over specific things and situations, and others report more general feelings of anxiety. We worry about the outcomes of important events. We're nervous when we do things for the first time, such as going on a date, speaking to a group, or getting married. For some, anxiety is short-lived and does not interfere in their lives, other than causing mild discomfort. For others, anxiety can cause panicky feelings, prevent them from enjoying many activities, or interfere with their daily living. Anxiety is also related to addictive behavior in two ways: (1) we often experience anxiety when practicing new nonaddictive behaviors, and (2) we temporarily reduce anxiety by engaging in addictive behavior.

This exercise will help you learn about your anxiety, so that you can develop strategies to cope with it and avoid returning to addictive behaviors to lessen it.

Anxiety has three components that interact with one another: (1) physical sensations, such as heart-pounding, sweating, and dizziness; (2) thoughts, such as expecting something terrible to happen; and (3) behavioral responses, such as leaving situations or avoiding places.

1. Please list the physical sensations that you experience when you feel anxiety. Sometimes our physical cues change as anxiety increases or decreases. Think about the most recent time you felt anxious, or the time you felt the worst anxiety. What were your physical sensations?

2. How have you coped in the past to reduce anxiety or avoid anxiety-producing situations?

3. What do you think about when you feel anxious? Imagine your anxiety as having a mind and will of its own. What would it say to you so that your anxiety level would rise? Often, our anxious thoughts will overestimate danger, underestimate help that is available to us or our ability to cope, and feed our existing insecurities. Please describe those thoughts and beliefs.

4. When we feel anxious, the emotional parts of our brains override the thinking parts. The result is often that we'll do anything that quickly relieves our discomfort. The problem is that this quick fix becomes a habit. Here's a solution to use in your journal: Following the example provided, list a physical symptom in the left-hand column, the thought connected with it in the center, and a reasonable and positive response in the column on the right.

Physical Sensation	Anxious Thought	Positive Response
<u>I feel warm.</u>	<u>I'm going to pass out.</u>	<u>I'll sit, relax, and cool down.</u>

5. Another way to get to know your anxiety is to create an intensity scale that ranges from very low to extremely high levels of anxiety. Please identify at least one situation or experience for each level, and the physical sensations that are associated with each.

Level of Anxiety	Situation/Experience	Physical Sensations
Very low		
Low		
Moderate		
High		
Very High		

6. In looking back over the information you've collected about your anxiety, what is a word or phrase you would use to describe or name it?

With your therapist or group, please make a plan to work against (your word or phrase) _____ and describe your plan here.

Be sure to bring this handout back to your next session with your therapist, and be prepared to talk about your thoughts and feelings about the exercise.